weapons and technology, whereas China is increasingly able to substitute arms imports with indigenous products. In other words, although India's defence expenditure is relatively high, the power gap vis-à-vis China is widening rapidly and, as such, it does not signal a clear-cut policy of hard balancing against China.

If we look beyond the defence spending/GDP ratio measuring balancing behaviour,[2] we find that India has indeed responded to its security concerns about China in various ways. India has made sustained efforts to enhance its military and deterrent capabilities vis-à-vis China. In response to Chinese infrastructure developments in the Himalayas and violations of their border, the Indian government in 2006 initiated a strategic roads programme improving road and railway capabilities on the Indian side. As Kalyanaraman elaborates, India is also strengthening military capabilities along the China front, developing Integrated Battle Groups (IBGs) meant to ensure faster punitive and defensive operations and equipped with light artillery and heavy lift helicopters. In fact, the IBG-styled exercise carried out by the Mountain Strike Corps in Arunachal Pradesh in early October 2019 upset China, and the Chinese Vice Foreign Minister Luo Zhaohui raised the issue with his Indian counterpart only a few days before the Modi–Xi Informal Summit in Chennai.[3] For its part, the Indian Air Force has repositioned Sukhoi-30 aircraft to the eastern sector and is expected to position a squadron of the new Rafale aircraft as well as heavy-lift and advanced combat helicopters to the border areas.

India is also enhancing its naval capabilities in order to undertake HADR operations, fulfil its constabulary duties, and protect sea lanes of communications but also to monitor and manage China's growing sea power and increased ambitions in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR). At the core is India's fear of Chinese encirclement through a naval